

The Legend of Sweeney Todd

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Famous nowadays for its on-screen and on-stage presence, the barber of Fleet Street was born a newspaper character. Created in 1846 in Edward Lloyd's People's Periodical and Family Library, Sweeney Todd appeared as one of the main protagonists of a 'penny blood' anonymously published under the title The String of Pearls.

Like many other stories of the same genre, the tale was woven around sensationalism: theft, disappearances and murder, which pervade the original story to catch the interest of its audience. The plot of The String of Pearls starts with the arrival of Lieutenant Thornhill in London, coming back from a long journey in the Far East: he carries a beautiful necklace he is meant to give to the angel-like Johanna as a present from her lover Mark Ingestriv, who vanished at sea while he was on the same crew as Thornhill.

Sweeney Todd was a quiet and somewhat eccentric barber practising his profession right next to the church of St Dunstan-in-the-West (located at 186a Fleet Street). He stole the string of pearls when the lieutenant came in for a shave and mysteriously disposed of his victim. The story, published in weekly episodes, therefore takes the shape of a long-term investigation led by Johanna, Tobias and other detective-like characters, aiming at solving the problem of Thornhill's vanishing and Sweeney Todd's ways of "polishing off" his victims. The reader is stricken by horror at the revelation of Todd's scheme, famously the use of the victims' corpses as the main ingredient for Mrs Lovett's delicious Meat Pies. Indeed, the discovery of the bodies in the vaults under the church of St Dunstan, investigated

after a horrible smell started to fill the holy building, enables Todd to be stopped and hanged publicly, while Mrs Lovett dies of poison a few pages earlier.

The tale finishes as a form of moral lesson, rewarding the heroes and punishing the sadistic greediness of the two criminals.

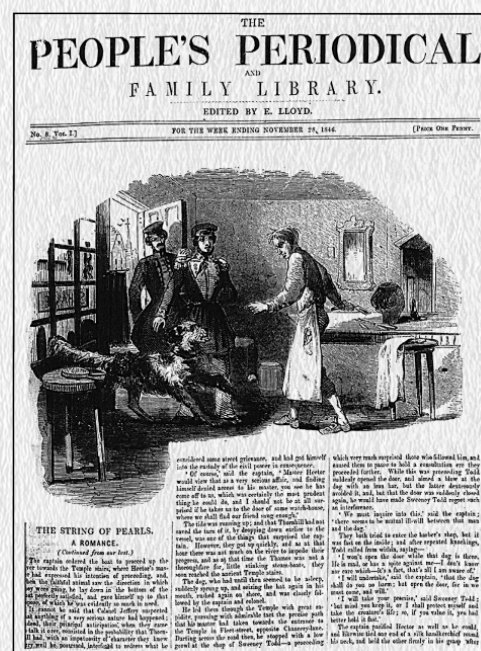
While fictitious, Sweeney Todd's barbershop is set in Fleet Street, but the text does not mention the exact location. Based on the proximity of his shop and the church of St Dunstan, which are both connected by a secret imaginary passageway in the story, it has been identified by Robert Mack as being located at number 186. Discussion, however, continues, and another hypothesis sets Todd's shop at the current position of the Old Bank pub (194 Fleet Street).

With its melodramatic nature, the simple story failed to convince the critics to include the String of Pearls within the Literary Canon, and therefore its popularity remained oral, through the

narration of Sweeney Todd's murders by local inhabitants or through the re-enactment of the plot by numerous dramatic adaptations. Yet, the writing of Sweeney Todd's story inherits a tradition of urban tales shared within the lower classes whose living conditions as London's poor in the early 19th century can be summarised as proximity to cemeteries, a lack of infrastructure, darkness, dirt, and the harshness of industrial work. Part of the popular culture of the time lay in the expression of an anxiety related to the circumstances of city life and explains the portrayal of a grisly killing in the shade of London alleys through the character of Sweeney Todd.



St Dunstan-In-the-West

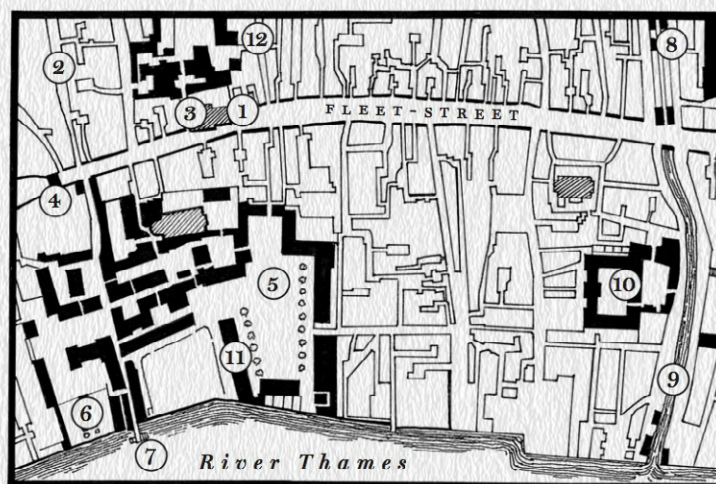


One of the alleged homes of Sweeney Todd. Fleet Street.

SWEENEY TODD'S LONDON

KEY

1. Sweeney Todd's barbershop (186 Fleet-street)
2. Mrs Lovett's Pie-shop (Bell-yard)
3. St Dunstan's church (St Dunstan in the West)
4. Temple-bar
5. The Temple
6. Temple-gardens
7. Temple-stairs
8. Fleet Market
9. Fleet Ditch
10. Bridewell Prison
11. Paper-buildings
12. Fetter-lane



A map by Robert Mack published in "Sweeney Todd: the demon barber of Fleet Street", 2010